

The Proof: Lessons in Leading Public Health Communication of Alcohol-Related Cancer Risk Using a Multimedia Campaign and Knowledge Mobilization Toolkit

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Category: Population Health and Health Services

Our Goals

- 1

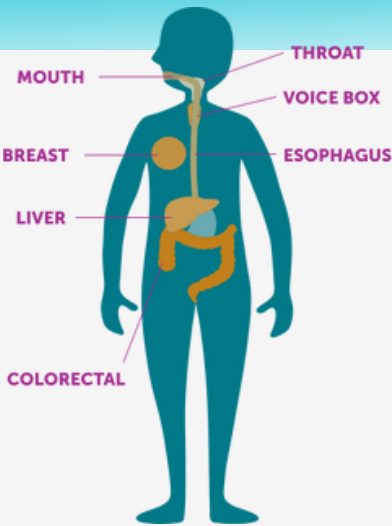
Create evidence-based tools for understanding Canada’s new low-risk drinking guidelines and assessing alcohol-related cancer risk.
- 2

Establish a collaborative public health campaign to raise awareness about the link between alcohol and cancer.
- 3

Evaluate campaign impact with a mixed-methods approach, applying insights to future public health messaging.

Background

- Alcohol contributed to 7,000 cancer cases in Canada (2020), with studies confirming its role in increasing the risk of certain cancers (breast, throat, esophagus, colon, rectum, and liver).¹
- 1 in 5 Canadian adults increased their alcohol consumption during the COVID-19 pandemic.²
- Canada’s Guidance on Alcohol and Health, released in January 2023, introduced a new risk continuum expressed in standard drinks per week, replacing the Low-Risk Alcohol Drinking Guidelines (2011).³
- BC Cancer launched a provincial campaign to promote the new guidelines and empower individuals to make evidence-informed choices about their health.



Methods

- In collaboration with B.C.’s Ministry of Health and a population and public health consulting firm, BC Cancer launched a multimedia campaign, “The Proof”, to raise awareness about alcohol and cancer risk.
- The target demographic was B.C. residents ages 25-49 who consume alcohol.



- Province-wide advertising mimicking traditional alcohol marketing, social media, strategic partnerships, and a website with a knowledge mobilization toolkit was developed.
- The toolkit featured a Standard Drink Calculator Quiz for individuals to personalize their weekly alcohol intake.
- Outcomes assessment used social media and web analytics, online pop-up surveys, and street-intercept surveys.

Results

- Over 37,000 new users visited The Proof website.
- 40% of quiz users were at high-risk, 28% at medium-risk, and 23% at low-risk for alcohol-related cancers.

Table 1: Standard Drink Calculator Quiz Usage and Associated Cancer-Risk Results			
Total # of Quiz Results	High-Risk	Medium-Risk	Low-Risk
1,706	670	470	396
% of Total Users	39.3%	27.5%	23.2%

- Approximately half of survey participants expressed a likelihood to drink less after seeing the campaign.

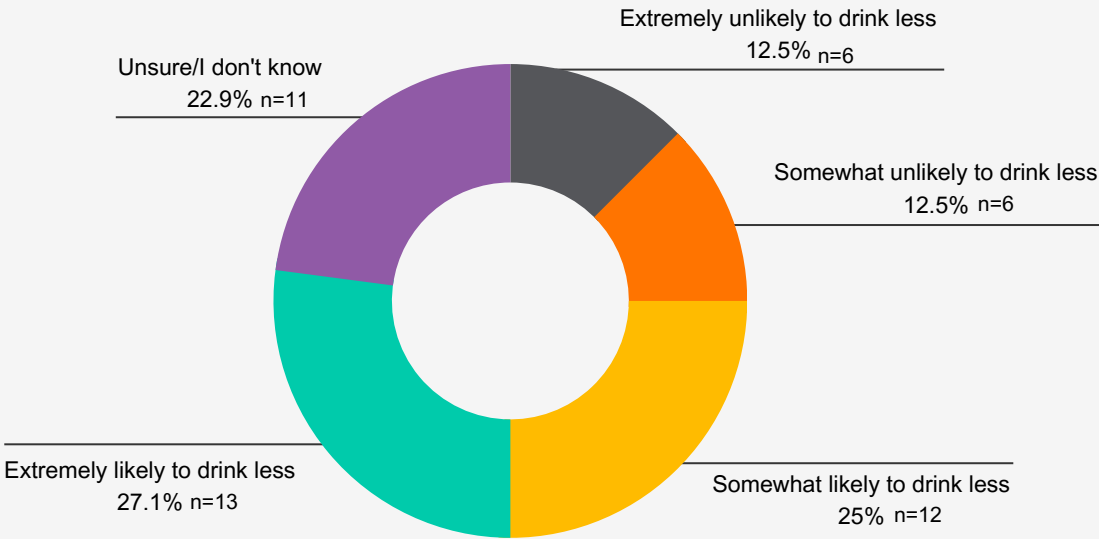


Figure 1: Outcome evaluation results for the survey question: “How likely are you to drink less after seeing this campaign?” (n=48)

Conclusions

- The campaign significantly increased knowledge among B.C. residents about the link between alcohol and cancer.
- Diverse forms of targeted online advertising lead to enhanced participant engagement.
- Strong indications of public interest in the science of alcohol and health highlight the value of partnerships with community stakeholders for knowledge mobilization.
- Future public health efforts should maintain a factual, non-judgemental, and non-stigmatizing approach to behaviour change.

Acknowledgements

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References

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- Canada’s Guidance on Alcohol and Health. Canadian Centre on Substance Use and Addiction. (2023).